

SHRIYA PATIL SHINDE



Salaria, continued to forcibly occupy the nullah. A single sq ft in Juhu can retail for up to Rs 25,000; so Salaria wasn't about to give up prime real estate. In January 2008, the Konkan Divisional Commissioner, Shreekant Singh, dismissed Salaria's appeal and passed an order to demolish the illegal offices of TRIG. Unsettlingly enough, Revenue Minister Narayan Rane stayed this order.

"At first, I felt helpless," Singh said. "But I'd come to the movement to resolve my helplessness and not despair even more. I knew I could either give up or go on. And I choose to forge forward."

"What did you do?" I asked her.

"We filed another RTI application to uncover why Rane stayed the commissioner's order, and if his stay order was valid."

"And what did you find?"

"I've used innumerable RTI applications to get information and then act on the data. This was the first time my RTI drew a blank. Obviously, our opponent had friends in all the right places."

When the RTI resulted in naught, local residents and activists, including Singh, went on a fast to protest political intrusion in development projects. Some claimed that the Trig Guard Force, a team of several hundred men, was often summoned by politicians in self-protection or for raising a ruckus but everyone, naturally, dismissed this rumour. Singh and other Juhu residents swiftly swung into action and petitioned to meet Chief Minister Vilasrao Deshmukh. A meeting, led by filmmaker and Juhu resident Mahesh Bhatt, was organised.

Missing green: Land tracts along the Juhu beach (above) were turned into ecologically sensitive gardens by its residents

Driving Home a Point

OPEN SPACES HAVE TO REMAIN OPEN. LAND HAS TO CATCH WATER. AIR HAS TO BE CLEAN. IF THE GOVERNMENT WON'T DO IT, MOTHERS WITH DAY JOBS AND FATHERS WITH DEADLINES WILL.

Deshmukh affirmed that the Revenue Minister had absolutely no right to stay the demolition order—only the housing department could issue a stay order in this matter. Tables turned. Six months after the stay order on the demolition order, Rane had to rescind his directive. In July, the TRIG offices were demolished, a landmark, heartening verdict for local citizenry, who audaciously took on political clout. And won.

Singh called on me earlier this year. The BMC, she pointed out, had done little to ease flooding in Juhu. Would I pitch in, she said, as I was also a Juhu resident? I promptly wrote a public letter to Jairaj Pathak, the BMC Municipal Commissioner, asking him to do his job—or get the hell out of public office. My letter pointed to a massive green zone in Juhu, owned by the Airports Authority of India, a catchment area for monsoon excess. But this green zone, over a hundred acre, was exploited on one end by the dispossessed—a slum—and on the other, by the rich—a parking lot. In the bargain, this oval, the lungs of Juhu, no longer holds the excess rain water. And this water, in the bargain, floods our streets, and our houses. "We're working to insure the land stays a green zone, and the status of the Juhu Lake is secure," Singh assured me. "We want open spaces to remain open. For land to catch water. For air to be clean. If we don't do this for our children, who will?"

Men and women across India now see that politics, when it's practised by a few, even within a democracy, can be a threat to their personhood. Women like Sherly Singh, mothers with day jobs, recognise that unless they don't wrest politics out of the hands of politicians, their world is going up for grabs. This makes their singular action of interrogation and resistance almost incendiary, and always heroic. Now the challenge is upon our leaders: for the middle-classes, they assume, anaesthetised by television are actually active associates in decisions that shape the future of their children. This constituency is ready to take the babu brigade to the cleaners. Don't you know, Tracy Chapman sang, "They're talkin' about a revolution". If our leaders don't sit up and listen hard, whispers of millions of Indians will be loud and lyrical enough to blow up their ears and bring down their roof.

The author, who lives in Mumbai, won the Betty Trask Award and the Premio Grinzane Cavour for his first novel, The Last Song of Dusk.